Best Practices and Style Guide Sample

QA Technical Editor

Note:
As this is the first Style and Best Practices Guide, this is also a preliminary draft. The guidelines and rules set forth in this document will grow and change as the group and curricula grow and change. Therefore, this is considered a "living document". In areas where "TBD" has been indicated, additional content will be added as per a group consensus and/or when specific issues/items arise and need to be addressed.

To request changes or additions for this guide, please contact the QA Editor or ID Manager.

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BEST PRACTICES

PRACTICE		DETAIL
1.	Be specific about internal deliverables.	This allows for proper planning and time-management of all UMA participants.
2.	Utilize efficient storage and tracking of learning assets across the organization leverages the investment in content creation.	Lost or misplaced learning assets are a waste of time and money, and many times cause undue rework by team members.
3.	• Prepare for variation in learning styles. • Use multiple instructional methods (verbal and non-verbal) to improve retention.	✓ Use audio, video, and animation to support different learning styles, optimize memory and brain utilization. ✓ Limit use of text to business of screens. ✓ Use graphics where possible. ✓ Use real world examples. ✓ Refer to 508 Standard (http://www.section508.gov/index.cfm?fuseAction=stdsSum).
4.	Structure course in a well-organized manner, and make it easy to navigate.	✓ Content should be divided into modular chunks /learning units, appropriately labeled, and presented in a logical manner. ✓ Materials should be divided into short, readable ("chunked") sections (5-10 minutes in duration) with links to subsequent pages, if necessary. ✓ Include computerized or manual prompts to perform certain behaviors. ✓ Make navigation and segues simple, yet in support of computer-savvy AND computer-novice user levels. ✓ Include computerized or manual prompts to perform certain behaviors. ✓ Students should be able to intuitively get from place to place within the course. ✓ Ensure that response time of environment matches as closely to learner as possible. ✓ Pages should download within a reasonable period of time even without a high-speed Internet connection.
5.	Align learning activities to objectives and outcomes.	✓ Use your objectives and outcomes to determine your learning activities. ✓ Be consistent.
6.	Use your objectives and outcomes to determine your assessments.	For example, if one of your objectives states that students will evaluate a topic, make sure the assessment has a corresponding essay question that asks students to evaluate.
7.	Content should be an active (not passive) experience.	Employ a high level of interactivity to keep learners engaged.
8.	Greet your students with a welcome message, and tell them how to get started in the course.	Refer them back to Orientation unit as needed.
9.	Introduce each learning unit with a brief overview of the topic.	Write and post objectives for each learning unit.
10.	Connect what the students already know about the topic to what they are going to learn.	This can include questions or activities to make this connection. Recalling prior knowledge should help provide a context for the students and get them excited about the learning tasks ahead of them.
11.	Ensure that students understand what is required for them to succeed in an online course.	✓ Detail the general course content and student responsibilities; Learning outcomes should be diverse and well-defined. ✓ Consider/cover the essential skills and knowledge that a student should be able to demonstrate upon completion of the course. ✓ Share a set of very clear expectations for your students and for yourself as to (1) how you will communicate and (2) how much time students should be working on the course each week.
12.	Ensure that the breadth of your content covers all of the content in the course outline of record; and that it is clearly written.	If your course doesn't cover everything in the course outline, students won't learn everything they are supposed to learn.

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PRACTICE		DETAIL
13.	Extend your students' learning with optional web resources and post model submission assignments.	✓ For students who want to learn more on their own, provide links to web sites that you think will be helpful. ✓ Conversely, you can also provide links that will help remediate students who struggled through a topic.
14.	When designing lengthy quizzes or exams, design them so students see one question at a time.	✓ This way, each answer gets saved once the student goes to the next question, which is helpful in case the student's browser times out. ✓ If you decide that you really want all of the questions presented on the same screen, consider dividing the lengthy exam in multiple shorter exams, and tell students to save answers after each question.
15.	Plan a good closing and wrap activity for the course.	As courses come to a close, it is easy to forget the value of a good closing experience. In the final hours of a course, students are likely to be stressed and not take the time to do the lists and the planning that can help reduce stress and provide a calming atmosphere. For example: ✓ Take time to remind students of what's next – perhaps in the form of a "To Do" list ✓ As always, it is good to post reminders and make references to the planning list in your comments. And update as you go. ✓ Plan the ending of the course experience. A well-designed ending of a course provides opportunities for reflection and integration of useful knowledge. ✓ It is also a time to wrap up positive social and cognitive experiences.

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STYLE GUIDE

I OVERVIEW

A. Purpose of this guide

The purpose of this guide is to provide the instructional designers with editorial support and guidance. In addition to establishing good practices into the development system, the QA (Quality Assurance) Editor also provides the course, process, and organization with a necessary review milestone in maintaining course consistency and excellence.

B. Assumptions

Assumptions must be established at the beginning of each project. Such assumptions should/may include:

- Adherence to the established styles and best practices
- Scheduling of drafts and reviews – with an end goal of meeting the deadline as needed.
- Each manuscript requires its own scheduling
- Listing of SME, writer, and other participants in the creation of the manuscript
- Any anticipated issues with obtaining or verifying information
- All information contained within the manuscript is accurate and that resources can be provided for verification.

C. Why it's needed and what issues it will resolve

Incorporating a QA/ Technical Editing standard into course development provides the courses with consistency and structure. A QA process provides the courses and programs with a review process that helps catch grammatical, syntax, or sentence structure corrections.

The QA process also helps manage, develop, and foster a culture of excellence. It also helps to provide learners and professionals with a course, program, and overall product that reflect the expectations of a competitive academic institute.

Help Reference Listing

In addition to this guide, the ID/writer has several other reference sources to help in the development and writing of manuscripts. These include the Chicago Manual of Style, Webster's Dictionary, etc. There is also a resource listing for how best practices and styles listed later on in this guide (see page 11)

The QA process is based on best practices (see page 4) from resources that are easily accessible by instructional designers (see page 11), instructors, program chairs and can be referenced during the QA Editing process.

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II ANALYSIS

A. Audience

The final audience is the student within a course. However; the internal audience encompasses instructional designers, media developers, program chairs, instructors, and the business at large.

B. Goal of course

The goal of any course is to help transfer information to the learner in a simple, effective, concise manner. As courses are developed with narratives which carry into multiple dialogs it becomes important to provide the learner with a clear understanding of the purpose of the message delivered through the dialogs, narratives, and scenarios.

1) What do learners need to know by the end of the course?

Learners need to understand the purpose of the message transferred through the learning activates and be able to apply or incorporate the information into practical situations. This means that the core message needs to be passed on effectively.

2) What are the desired learning outcomes?

The desired learning outcomes are for learners to be able to successfully meet the course objectives and supporting objectives through assignments, assessments, and discussions.

3) How will success be determined?

Success is determined when the students are able to comprehend and apply the purpose of the objectives in each course and see the relevance and importance of the final product of their work implemented in professional practice.

C. Prerequisites for learners

- **Introductory Courses:** The prerequisite for learners is for them to have acquired a GED or high school diploma.
- **Intermediate/Advanced Courses:** The prerequisite for learners will involve introductory courses as they relate to intro courses. These will be determined by instructors prior to course offerings.

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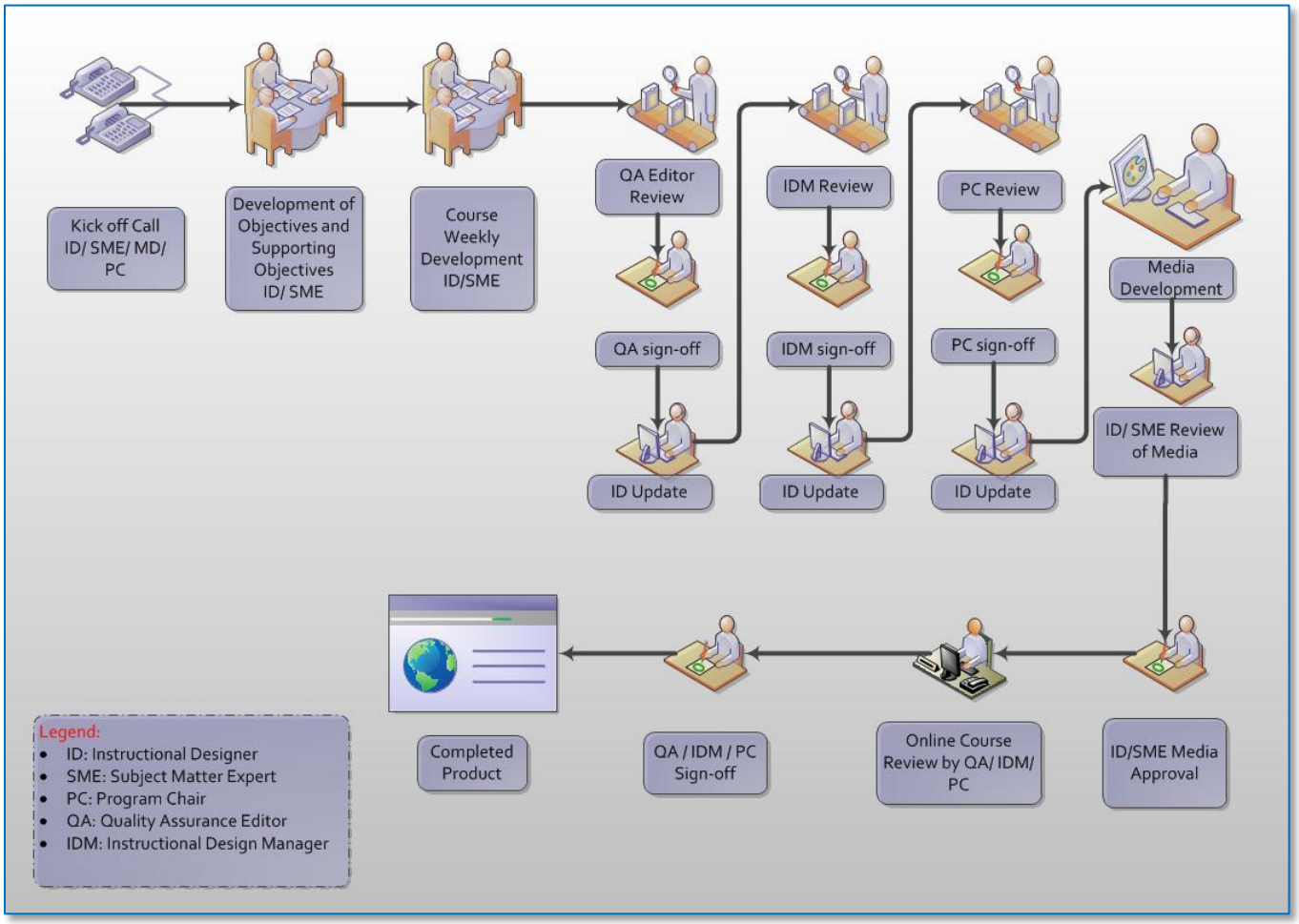
III Course Structure & Development

A. Workflow

The goal of any course is to help transfer information to the learner in a simple, effective, concise manner. As courses are developed with narratives which carry into multiple dialogs it becomes important to provide the learner with a clear understanding of the purpose of the message delivered through the dialogs, narratives, and scenarios.

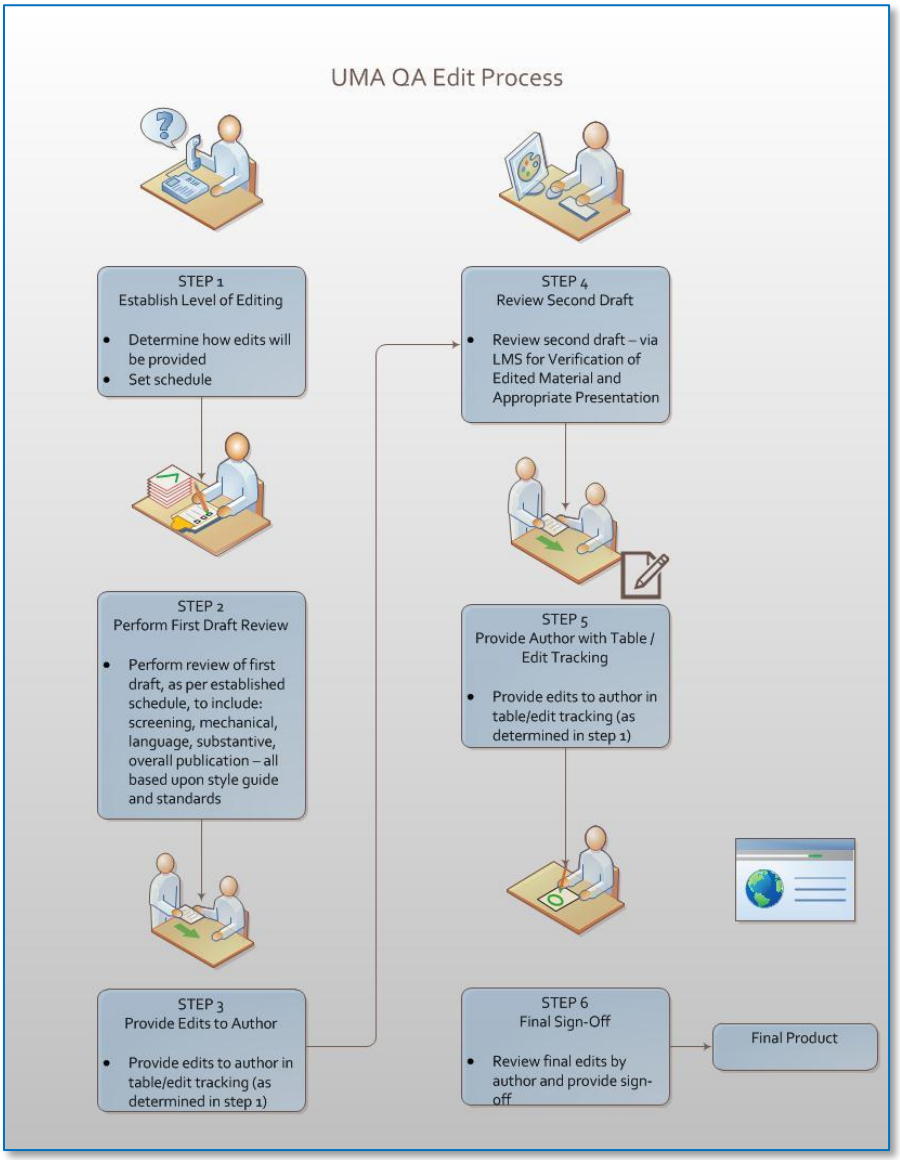
1) Overall workflow of course development



2) Workflow of QA process

STEP	TASK	TIME NEEDED (DAYS)
1)	▪ Establish level of editing (light/heavy, how many rounds of editing – 1 or 2) ▪ Determine how edits will be provided (i.e., in corrections table format or as edit tracking in Word) ▪ Set schedule (accordingly)	1
2)	▪ Perform review of first draft, as per established schedule, to include: screening, mechanical, language, substantive, overall publication – all based upon style guide and standards	1 to 4*
3)	▪ Provide edits to author in table/edit tracking (as determined in step 1). Formal editorial symbols will not be used. Straight forward comments, suggestions and questions to the author will be provided within the edited content. ▪ This content can be passed back to the editor by the author with responses where necessary (e.g., I do not agree with this change because …; answers to editor's questions; responses to suggestions, etc.)	
4)	▪ Review second draft – via LMS for Verification of Edited Material and Appropriate Presentation	1 to 2*
5)	▪ Provide edits to author in table/edit tracking (as determined in step 1)	
6)	▪ Review final edits by author and provide sign-off	1 to 2*

**This can vary and be shortened or extended according to length of manuscript.*



B. Templates

There are a series of templates used in the development of courses within each program. They are numbered in a series.

1. The Course Document which houses the overall course and will be the final manuscript is the template for course development and the foundation of the course in its manuscript form.

2. Gen3 Course Document Template f

2. The documents used with the Course Document are broken down into smaller items in order to provide individual templates for the ID and SME to easily manage the workflow and versioning. The documents are sequenced in alpha-numeric order.

The Course Document is 2. Course Document template
2a. SME Writing Document
2b. Weekly Introduction Template
2c. Weekly assignment Template
2d. Weekly Discussion Template
2e. Weekly Highlights Template
2f. Weekly Scenario Template
2g. Weekly Assessment Template
2g1. Weekly Assessment Sample
2h. Introduction to Rubrics

2a. Gen3 SME Writing Development
2b. weekly_introduction_
2c. weekly assignment_template
2d. weekly_discussion_te
2e. weekly_highlights_te
2f. weekly_scenario_tem
2g. weekly Assessment_Templat
2g-1. Weekly Assessment_Sample.
2h. Introduction to Rubrics.docx
2i. Gen3 Time on Task Breakdown for I

C. Description/Synopsis

The templates above describe each major item to be developed in a Course Week. This is the information that will eventually become part of the students' weekly learning environment. This should provide the learner/student with a broad, but concise description of what the course contains, as well as its objectives.

D. Units and topics

Units and topics are broken down weekly and are described in the attached files above.

E. Introductions and conclusions

The introductions and Summaries (conclusions) are narratives and need to be edited as such.

F. Chronology

The course is broken down into 5 weeks. Each week has graded deliverables but the course needs to be developed into an interactive learning environment full of scripted scenarios, presentations, and simulations.

IV GENERAL GUIDELINES

A. Language

- Active – use active voice
- Tense
  - ✓ Keep tenses consistent within sentences.
  - ✓ Do not change tenses when there is no time change for the action.
- Sentence length – avoid run-on sentences; use short, simple sentences
- Relevance – be sure all language is relevant to the topic at hand and doesn't wander or bring in elements without tied in basis
- SCRIPTS: When reviewing the narrative scripts for storyboards the analysis will focus on the following:
  - ✓ Does the script coincides with the story
  - ✓ Does the script defines the elements of each screen
  - ✓ Does the script provide architectural navigation to allow one screen to flow to the next
  - ✓ Does the script give an introduction about what will be taught, the actual text of what is being taught, and a summary stating what has been taught.

B. Numbered lists and bullets

TBD as group

C. Number, dates, and time formats

TBD as group

D. Use of acronyms (how and when)

TBD as group

E. Job aid examples (how, when, and objective)

The Three Types of Job Aids

- Job Aids for Procedures

  Examples:
  - ✓ First Time Login for New Users
  - ✓ How do I view online courses?
  - ✓ Accessing Course Materials 24/7
  - ✓ Accessing and Completing a Course Evaluation
- Job Aids for Informing

  Examples:
  - ✓ Troubleshooting Online Courses
  - ✓ Course FAQ's
- Job Aids for Coaching

  Examples:
  - ✓ Best ways to study for courses
  - ✓ How to prepare for an exam
  - ✓ These could also be course specific

F. Graphics standardization – style, size, use (when and how) to reinforce the content

Some flexibility is necessary. However, uniformity across the courses consistency in graphic content conveys the correct image. It also reassures the learner of continuity from unit to unit, course to course, etc.

Examples:

- ✓ Colors
- ✓ Size
- ✓ Location on screen (top, bottom, left right – relation to text, etc.)
- ✓ Shadows
- ✓ Rounded corners
- ✓ Feathering
- ✓ Borders
- ✓ Reflections
- ✓ Shape

G. Charts and illustrations

TBD by group, but should also follow similar guidelines to graphics standardization

H. Transitions (from concept to concept)

Transitions should smoothly relate one concept to the next to maintain continuity. It also allows for context, as well as easier retention and understanding by the learner.

I. Use of real or hypothetical scenarios to provide a real-world context to the learner

V PARTICIPANT-SPECIFIC ITEMS

A. Supplemental user workbook/printed course guide (?)

B. Assessment

C. Format and goals of questions

D. Descriptive feedback on answered questions (for both correct and incorrect answers)

E. Rubrics

VI MISCELLANEOUS

A. Legal issues (resources, accuracy guarantee, copyright, etc.)

As with all other educational organization the issue of plagiarism and copyright violations is an ongoing effort in quality assurance. In order to manage our content and our resources it is imperative that we use materials that are original to UMA and media elements that have been developed in-house or approved for usage.

- http://www.ala.org/advocacy/copyright
- http://www.copyright.gov/

B. Need for accessibility and Section 508

Is access for the disabled a requirement? Is it necessary for accreditation?

- http://www.justice.gov/crt/508/

C. Citations/Resources

Proposed List of Approved Sources and Guidelines for Manuscript Styles and Best Practices

Resource Owner	Resource
Style Guide Resources	
FEMA	https://www.firstrespondertraining.gov/rtdc/state/templates/styleguide.pdf
WWW.INC.COM : *Leslie O'Flahavan and Marilynne Rudick*	http://www.inc.com/articles/2001/06/22853.html
Pennwell Authors' Style Guide, Pennwell Corporation, Tulsa Oklahoma	http://www.pennwellauthors.com/manuscript_style.cfm
Smarter Balanced Assessment Consortium	http://www.smarterbalanced.org/wordpress/wp-content/uploads/2012/05/TaskItemSpecifications/Guidelines/StyleGuide/StyleGuide.pdf
Guildford Publications Manuscript Preparation Guide Guilford Publications, Inc	http://www.guilford.com/authors/styleguide.pdf
University of Colorado	https://www.cusys.edu/eld-catalog/docs/ELD_StyleGuide2011.pdf
CBT Design Guide Montgomery College Center for Professional and Organizational Development Technology Training Unit 05/05/2006	http://www.montgomerycollege.edu/Departments/cpod/elearning/instruction/class/cbt_design/docs/CBT_Design_Guide.pdf
Reuters Book of Journalism – TV Scripts	http://handbook.reuters.com/index.php?title=Television_Scripts
Best Practices Resources	
The Annapolis Coalition Behavioral Health Workforce Education & Training	http://www.annapoliscoalition.org/resources/1/best_practices_manuscript.pdf
Designbydi - Creating Usable Websites: B. Dianne Calhoun, MA Instructional Design	http://www.designbydi.com/documents/BestPracticesFinal.pdf
Designing for Learning: Judith V. Boettcher, Ph.D.	http://www.designingforlearning.info/services/writing/ecoach/tenbest.html
Course Avenue: The Best e-Learning Software and Services	http://www.courseavenue.com/documents/elearning-best-practices.pdf
Las Positas College, Livermore, CA*	http://lpc1.clpccd.cc.ca.us/lpc/blackboard/best_practices/
E-learning Brothers	http://elearningbrothers.com/10-design-standards-to-create-better-elearning/

**This resource was the best and most comprehensive in my opinion – it is also the one I used the most for creating the Best Practices for the updated Style Guide.*

VII GLOSSARY

TBD

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